Except that the man recounting this incident was the son of the school owner. Overhearing the blatant lie, this person confronted Sukash. A few slaps later, Sukash managed to escape and simply vanished from the scene for some time.

Not before learning something from the incident, though. That it was better to deceive people over the phone than in person. Before long, he had learned all that he needed to make a convincing impression as a person of influence on the phone. He freely used fake identities, modulated his voice and routed calls through government offices. After a second arrest in Bengaluru in 2009, he moved briefly to Madurai where he tried to dupe a cinema hall manager by promising him a new digital sound system. When the con backfired, Sukash tried to strangle the manager and was later arrested.

The following year, he moved to Chennai where he continued his con games. It was here that he first met his wife and later accomplice Leena Maria Paul, who was then a small-time Malayali actress. Born and brought up in Dubai to parents originally from Thrissur, Leena had dropped out of a dental sciences course in Bengaluru to pursue a career in films. She came to Chennai following an offer by Sukash to work in a Tamil film he would produce. He came to meet in her in Chennai in a luxury car with a red beacon and flanked by an assistant. He even created a persona to match—introducing himself as none other than the grandson of Karunanidhi, the chief minister at the time. Sukash and Leena fell in love and started living together, even after she discovered that her lover was nothing more than a petty conman.

People who saw them together at the time say it was an intense love affair. Sukash would drop Leena at work and wait outside the studio where she anchored a small segment in a TV series. When the show was abruptly pulled off the air, Sukash took the distraught Leena to a candlelit dinner in a five-star hotel, recalls an actor who knew Leena. Once, when her phone broke during a film shoot, she cried inconsolably as it was a token of love from Sukash. They both reportedly had each other's names tattooed on their arms, a claim police officials have not been able to verify.

It still isn't clear whether Leena had become Sukash's partner in crime by 2011, but she did help Devaraja, then chasing the fraudster for several cheating cases in Bengaluru, arrest him that year at a traffic junction in Chennai. Interestingly, Sukash was driving a yellow Tata Nano at the time. The conman was soon out on bail and headed to Kerala to make up with his wife who had meanwhile returned to her home state. The rapprochement seems complete, as Leena herself is now allegedly involved in diverting and routing her husband's illegal earnings through Nail Artistry, a luxury nail art salon that she runs, with offices in Kochi, Chennai and Bengaluru. According to the ED, Nail Artistry's earnings—it made Rs 4.79 crore in Chennai and Rs 1.21 crore in Kochi in FY21—are believed to be part of the Rs 200 crore Sukash extorted from his last con. Leena is currently an accused in four cases of cheating.

The couple stayed in Kochi till 2012, when Sukash was forced to flee the city after a textile group filed a case of cheating against him. He had taken Rs 20 lakh from the Kochi-based Emmanuel Silks, promising them that he would get Bollywood actor Katrina Kaif for a promotional programme that they were planning to host. He brought Telugu star Allu Arjun (who was yet to become the sensation that he did after *Pushpa*) instead, to inaugurate their showroom in Kottayam. Katrina was promised for a later date, but by then Sukash had moved to another city and fresh missions.



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He chose his victims carefully, primarily targeting those who were either greedy or had a difficult job to be done, like a contract or a court case or a school admission